

Gender and cross-boundary mobility preferences: the moderating effects of organisational and occupational contexts

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The role of gender in career mobility is a major practical and scholarly concern. Drawing on boundaryless career literature and social role theory, we examined whether gender influences employees' psychological mobility, whether this influence varies depending on the nature of career boundaries (the boundaries of job, organisation and industry) and whether it is contingent on organisational or occupational characteristics. We conducted cross-classified multilevel analyses on 3,527 Australian employees nested within 725 organisations and 43 occupations. The results suggest that females show higher mobility preferences than males when it comes to crossing industries but not changing organisations or jobs. However, their preference for crossing career boundaries is significantly reduced when their organisation has a strong presence of female leadership. We also find that in female-dominated occupations, females show a higher cross-organisational mobility preference than males, while in male-dominated occupations, females show a lower cross-organisational mobility preference.

Keywords: cross-classified multilevel modelling, female leadership, gender, mobility preference, occupational gender segregation

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Key points

- 1 Female employees are different from male employees in their attitudes toward cross-boundary career mobility due to gendered societal expectations.
- 2 In general, female employees seem to be more open to boundaryless careers – especially cross-industry career progression – than males.
- 3 Practitioners should carefully consider the gender composition of organisational and occupational contexts when understanding employees' career preferences.
- 4 When a firm has many female leaders, its female employees prefer to stay.
- 5 In male-dominated occupations, female employees are less likely than men to move between organisations.

Introduction

Do female workers prefer to move across jobs more than males? How does gender determine employees' attitudes and behaviours toward their careers? These are important questions as more women participate in the increasingly flexible labour market (Carvalho et al. 2018; Dashper 2020; Kundi, Hollet-Haudebert and Peterson 2021; Rocha and Van Praag 2020; Wegemer and Eccles 2019). The importance of this question has heightened in recent years, as new digital technologies and disruptive events such as COVID-19 further complicate the mobility dynamics, as they displace existing jobs, generate novel career pathways and create new forms of temporary careers (Cho 2020; Daugherty and Wilson 2019; Duggan et al. 2022; Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). Employees are making more transitions, building their careers by moving across a variety of boundaries between jobs, organisations, industries, occupations and geographic locations (Lyons, Schweitzer and Ng 2015; McPherson 2018; Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). This phenomenon was examined for some time under the rubric of 'new career', and many concepts, such as the boundaryless career, have been proposed (Arthur 2014). Understanding the gender dynamics of career mobility is a critical concern for managers. Many organisations today are aware of the strategic importance of gender diversity and wish to build a diverse and inclusive organisational environment (Jeong and Harrison 2017; Kim et al. 2021; Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019). However, they often find it challenging to retain employees with diverse backgrounds. Therefore, it is important to understand how females respond to the new labour market realities differently than males.

Scholars have noticed that male and female workers often have different career attitudes and behaviours, resulting in different career trajectories (Kossek, Su and Wu 2017; Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019; Rocha and Van Praag 2020). Though the influence of gender on mobility preference and turnover pattern has received substantial scholarly attention (Bardoel et al. 2020; Huang, Xing and Gamble 2019; Mölders et al. 2019; Peltokorpi, Allen and Froese 2015; Ruiz-Palomo, Leon-Gomez and García-Lopera 2020), ambiguous results have been found (Mölders et al. 2019). While some have argued that women are

more likely to stay in their current jobs than men (e.g. Royalty 1998; Sousa-Poza and Sousa-Poza 2000), others have argued that women are more likely to move across employers (e.g. Kornblum, Unger and Grote 2018; Lee, Kim and Kim 2021; Rasheed, Iqbal and Mustafa 2018; Yanadori and Kato 2009), while still others found no gender differences in turnover (e.g. Kattenbach et al. 2014). Distinguishing different motivations, some studies have found that men have higher voluntary turnover (e.g. Lyness and Judiesch 2001), whereas women engage in more unplanned turnover (e.g. Bardoel et al. 2020). Drawing on the social role theory of gender (Anglin et al. 2022; Eagly 1987), the present study aimed to advance our understanding of gender roles in career choices by examining gender difference in career mobility preference across different boundaries (Tschoopp, Grote and Gerber 2014; Uy et al. 2015). Instead of actual mobility, our study investigated employees' preferences to directly identify their attitudes, since employees could either be pushed out or opt out (Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019). This is particularly important because preference better reflects employees' career attitudes.

This study advances our understanding of how gender is related to career preference. In particular, it makes three contributions to the literature on gender and career. First, we take into account the multiplicity of career boundaries (job, organisation and industry), refining the understanding of 'boundary' in boundaryless careers (Inkson et al. 2012). Scholars have increasingly considered the boundaryless career as a metaphor for a diversity of career boundaries, and the assumption of disappearing boundaries has been widely criticised (Inkson et al. 2012; Kornblum et al. 2018; Loacker and Śliwa 2016). As Rodrigues and Guest (2010, 1170) argued, we are actually witnessing not a 'demise but rather a redefinition, a growing complexity, and a more subjective perspective on career boundaries'. To date, the employee mobility literature has primarily focused on one type of boundary: the inter-organisational boundary. This is unfortunate, as individuals move across not only organisational boundaries but also other types of boundaries (Guan et al. 2019; Mawdsley and Somaya 2016). Therefore, recognising the complexity of career boundaries and understanding the differential effects of these boundaries are essential to advancing our knowledge of individuals' career attitudes and actions (Arthur and Rousseau 1996; Guan et al. 2019; Gubler, Arnold and Coombs 2014). Considering the different types of boundaries could be especially important for understanding gender's role in career mobility. Prior studies on gender-based career dynamics focused on within-industry career mobility (e.g. Gorji, Carney and Prakash 2020). In contrast, the present study offers a new way of understanding the mixed observations made in past studies on gender's role in boundaryless careers.

Second, this study introduced a multilevel framework to investigate gender's influence on cross-boundary mobility preferences. Understanding the antecedents of boundaryless careers is one of the core topics in career scholarship (Inkson et al. 2012). Rodrigues et al. (2019, 9) advised that we should be cautious against 'the excessive focus on individual agency in contemporary careers research'. Scholars have criticised previous studies for overlooking contextual constraints when discussing boundaryless careers (Afioni 2014; Guest and Rodrigues 2014), arguing that gender workplace research should consider more

contextual variables to better understand individual differences (e.g. Ely and Padavic 2007; Ramaswami et al. 2010). Responding to these concerns, this study examined the moderating effects of gender-related organisational and occupational contexts in the relationship between gender and mobility preferences. Specifically, two gender (in)equality indicators – female representation in leadership in an organisation and occupational gender segregation – were chosen (Kulik 2022).

Third, we analysed a nationally representative dataset collected in Australia in studying gender differences of career preference. Prior Australia-based studies of gender and career mobility mainly focused on particular occupational contexts, either those with minority female representation such as science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) jobs (e.g. Lloyd et al. 2018), medical careers (e.g. Mayson and Bardoel 2021) and accounting (Morley et al. 2002), or female-dominated occupations such as hospitality and human resource management (e.g. Adamovic and Leibbrandt 2023; McCabe 2008). Although several previous studies of career mobility utilised nationally representative data such as Income and Labor Dynamics in Australia (HILDA), they could not examine the subjective attitudes toward career mobility (e.g. Johnston and Lee 2012; Risse 2020). By using a large national dataset that was collected across occupations in Australia, this study offers more generalisable insights into women's mobility preferences.

Theoretical background and hypotheses

Gender and mobility preferences

Conflicting results exist regarding the gendered-differential effects on employees' mobility and turnover. While some scholars argue that women are less likely to change jobs than men because they are happy in their current jobs (e.g. Sousa-Poza and Sousa-Poza 2000) or find it more difficult to move (e.g. Royalty 1998), other scholars argue that women are more likely to move across organisations than men (e.g. Yanadori and Kato 2009). Pelto-korpi (2013) suggested that Japanese women are less embedded in their organisations and show higher turnover intentions than men. These conflicting results are partially due to overlooking the distinction between physical and psychological mobility. Psychological mobility refers to an employee's willingness and preference to move across certain boundaries (Sullivan and Arthur 2006). A career involves not only physical movements between jobs but also psychological mobility, which is enacted according to an individual's values, goals, aspirations and perceptions of their surrounding environment (Lyons et al. 2015; Valcour and Ladge 2008). Since psychological mobility is subject to the influence of an individual's social environment, it is likely to vary across genders, as women and men often find themselves living in different social worlds (Jiang et al. 2012). This study, which drew from gender role theory, argues that women tend to show higher levels of psychological mobility than men (Briscoe, Hall and DeMuth 2006; Sullivan and Arthur 2006; Uy et al. 2015).

According to gender role theory, women and men face different expectations based on their social roles. Women are expected to assume heavier family responsibilities than men

(Zhao et al. 2021). Even with women's increased labour market participation, traditional gender role distinctions remain largely unchanged (Forret, Sullivan and Mainiero 2010). In most families, the caregiving and parenting responsibilities fall to women, whereas the breadwinning responsibility falls to men. This division of work in the family inevitably leads to women having high levels of family commitments, which divert their time and effort from the workplace. Also, according to some studies, women still spend more time outside the workplace than men (e.g. Kauhanen and Napari 2015).

The social norms surrounding gender roles lead to gender-based differences in psychological mobility and career trajectories. When choosing jobs, women tend to consider more amenities (e.g. workplace flexibility) than men (Goldin and Katz 2016). Additionally, since, as per social norms, the husband's career demands are often prioritised, women's career decisions have to be more flexible and boundaryless to conform with their husbands' career trajectories (Brett and Stroh 1997; Valcour and Tolbert 2003). Hence, women tend to take a boundaryless career attitude in terms of their readiness and willingness to change jobs or organisations in response to family issues. In contrast, men are more likely to be locked into traditional work roles and have less mobility due to the social expectation that they financially support their families (Mainiero and Sullivan 2005). Also, Forret et al. (2010) found that men and women react differently to unemployment. Their conclusion supports the breadwinner role of men, for whom unemployment indicates a failure to fulfil social expectations. Women, however, are more likely to react to unemployment positively, as they tend to consider it an opportunity to adjust their careers and social lives. In conclusion, the different social roles outside the workplace suggest that men and women have different career attitudes. Thus, we proposed the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1. All else being equal, female employees have higher cross-boundary mobility preference than male employees.

Earlier research on boundaryless careers tended to focus on organisational borders (Gubler et al. 2014; Rodrigues and Guest 2010). With the advancement of the literature on the concept of the boundaryless career, it has been extended to include other types of boundaries, such as occupational, industrial, geographic and other subjective or psychological boundaries (Inkson et al. 2012). Different boundaries have different effects, though these effects have been claimed to be disappearing according to the boundaryless career theory. For example, some boundaries are easier to cross than others. There might be less cost incurred by employees when moving across organisations within the focal industry than across different industries (Starr, Ganco and Campbell 2018). Therefore, it is insightful to bring back boundaries to fully understand how career trajectories change and to what extent careers become boundaryless (Inkson et al. 2012).

This study considered boundaries' distance property, which is defined as the psychological difference between the boundaries and employees' employment status quo. Based on this definition, the boundary distance increases as individuals move from across jobs within

an organisation to across industries. Moreover, crossing a distant boundary (such as industry) increases the possibility of moving out of an employee's expertise or comfort zone. This study argues that the relationship between gender and mobility preference depends on the focal boundary's distance: when the boundary is more distant, women show higher mobility preferences than men. According to our previous arguments, the motivation for women's boundaryless careers is their commitment to social roles outside the workplace, which is less related to the boundary they are about to cross. For men, however, crossing distant boundaries accrues risks to their social role as financial supporters. We thus contend that the more distant the boundary, the more different female and male employees are regarding boundaryless careers. Thus, we proposed the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2. Gender differences in cross-boundary mobility preference are more pronounced as the boundary becomes more distant.

Organisational context: female leadership

Organisational contexts play a significant role in the dynamics between gender and career (Britton 2000; Cooke and Xiao 2014). Organisations are the immediate places where employees enact their career aspirations. Even with the emergence of boundaryless careers, the role of organisational institutions is not negligible. Among the potentially important features of organisational contexts, this study focused on female leadership as a contingency that would affect gendered differences in mobility preferences.

In most societies, gender differences are reflected in organisational hierarchy (Evans and Maley 2021). Women are often disadvantaged when it comes to promotions (Carvalho et al. 2018; Ramaswami et al. 2010). Men still dominate leadership positions, even when the level of human capital is indistinguishable (Buser, Niederle and Oosterbeek 2014). Meritocracy does not always make any difference in this, as men are more likely to achieve the level of success defined by organisations (Castilla and Benard 2010). Consequently, the gender composition of leadership frequently favours men, with a high representation of men in senior positions. The male dominance in leadership positions signals to women that they have a limited future in the organisation, thus encouraging them to contemplate career options outside the organisation.

In contrast, an organisation with a high female representation in leadership signals gender equality (Kulik 2022), providing female employees with a sense that greater opportunities for internal career progression await them, therefore motivating them to stay in the organisation and follow the traditional career path. As studies have found, exposure to counter-stereotypic gender phenomena (e.g. female leaders) fuels women's aspirations to attain a leadership position and undermines their unconscious perceptions of stereotypical gender-leadership associations (Dasgupta and Asgari 2004; Davies, Spencer and Steele 2005). Female leaders could also be successful career role models for female employees (Dasgupta and Asgari 2004; Davies et al. 2005). This role model effect is particularly significant for disadvantaged individuals such as women more so than men

(Lockwood 2006), motivating women to pursue internal career progression. We thus proposed the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 3. Organisational female leadership moderates the relationship between gender and cross-boundary mobility preference: the positive relationship between females and mobility preference is weaker in organisations with high female representation in leadership positions.

Occupational context: occupational gender segregation

Another contextual factor worthy of attention is occupational gender segregation: the unbalanced distribution of male and female workers across different occupations (He et al. 2019). Even with increasing calls for gender equality, gender-based segregation persists (Miller and Hayward 2006; Rice and Barth 2017). Different occupations thus have their own embedded gender assumptions, because of either social constructions or actual task requirements. Occupations such as caring services, clerking and nursing are considered typically feminine, whereas others, such as STEM jobs, are considered typically masculine (Blickenstaff 2005). Influenced by such gendered assumptions or stereotypes, general perceptions concerning desired or appropriate occupations are formed from childhood (Hartung, Porfeli and Vondracek 2008; Vervecken, Hannover and Wolter 2013). Gender is thus a salient social force that shapes employees' occupational choices and career attitudes (Woods and Hampson 2010). In line with the gender role theory (Vervecken et al. 2013), scholars from labour economics suggest that gender-based occupational segregation is associated with women's tendency to choose flexible work arrangements and family-friendly working conditions in order to fulfil their socially expected roles (e.g. Leuze and Strauß 2016).

However, employees' occupational choices do not always adhere to gendered stereotypes. Women (men) in feminine (masculine) occupations are consistent with gendered stereotypes. Otherwise, they are considered counter-stereotypes (He et al. 2019). This study argues that women's higher level of mobility preferences than men's will be stronger in feminine occupations than in masculine ones. To elaborate this argument, we adopted a legitimacy perspective, since occupational gendered stereotypes or assumptions are socially constructed (Anteby, Chan and Dibenigno 2016). Women in feminine occupations are treated as typical members. Therefore, they tend to have more employment opportunities outside their current organisations, leading them to have higher psychological mobility (Rodrigues et al. 2019). In contrast, women in masculine occupations do not match the gendered stereotype of the focal occupation. Their minority status, with limited legitimacy as members of the occupation, indicates lower employability in the labour market. Due to the high risk of mobility, they may thus find themselves more comfortable developing their careers by staying in their current organisation than by crossing organisational boundaries. In this case, women are more likely to stay than leave, though men are often believed to have stronger career aspirations (Cooke and Xiao 2014). We thus

anticipated that in masculine occupations, women tend to show lower mobility preferences than men:

Hypothesis 4. Occupational gender segregation moderates the relationship between gender and cross-boundary mobility preference: the positive relationship between females and mobility preference is weaker in male-dominated occupations.

Method

Data

The data used were from the Australian Workplace Relation Study (AWRS), a large dataset collected in 2014 by the Fair Work Commission of Australia. Designed to be nationally representative in Australia, the AWRS, to the best of our knowledge, is the latest and largest Australia-wide dataset that matches employers to employees. Table 1 summarises some sample characteristics and descriptions of the data. The AWRS data are broadly comparable to other national population datasets published by the Australian Statistics Bureau, such as the ABS Counts of Australian Businesses catalogue (8165.0) and the ABS Labor Force survey catalogue (6291.0).

The participating organisations were asked to complete the employer survey and distribute the employee survey to their workers. The employer survey gathered detailed information about various aspects of human resources, while the employee survey addressed a range of workplace experiences, including employees' mobility preferences. Of the 2,929 firms that agreed to participate in the survey, 1,380 completed both surveys, with a response rate of 47%. After excluding employees with missing values for important variables, the final sample comprised data obtained from 3,527 employees nested within 43 occupations and 725 organisations. As depicted in Figure 1, our data had a cross-classified multilevel structure with two levels: employees who were simultaneously nested within occupations and organisations. On average, 82 individuals ($SD = 92$) were embedded in each occupation, while five individuals ($SD = 3.5$) were embedded in each organisation. The final sample was not significantly different from the initial data in terms of gender, tenure, relationship status, age, wage etc. Further information about the data can be found on the Fair Work Commission's website (www.fwc.gov.au).

Measures

Independent variables

There were three main predictors in our empirical models – gender, female leadership and occupational gender segregation. *Gender*, the individual-level predictor, was a binary variable, with 1 meaning 'female' and 0 meaning 'male'. The other two higher-level predictors were treated as moderators in this model. The *female manager proportion* was used to measure female leadership by dividing the number of female managers (including senior and mid-level management positions) by the total number of managers. The occupational gender segregation was calculated and aggregated from individual data. The AWRS survey

Table 1 Summary of sample characteristics

Employee level	Number	Percentage	Organisation level	Number	Percentage
Language spoken at home			Industry^d		
English	3022	85.68	Mining	21	2.90
Non-English ^a	482	13.66	Manufacturing	65	8.97
Age^b			Electricity, gas, water and waste service	16	2.21
15–24 years	346	9.81	Construction	39	5.38
25–34 years	915	25.94	Wholesale trade	47	6.48
35–44 years	851	24.13	Retail trade	68	9.38
45–54 years	808	22.91	Accommodation and food services	57	7.86
55–64 years	472	13.38	Transport, postal and warehousing	32	4.41
More than 64 years	49	1.39	Information media and telecommunication	20	2.76
Occupations^c			Financial and insurance services	28	3.86
Managers	703	19.94	Rental, hiring and real estate services	29	4.0
Professionals	817	23.16	Professional, scientific and technical	24	3.31
Technicians and trades workers	295	8.36	Administrative and support services	39	5.38
Community and personal service workers	253	7.17	Public administration and safety	18	2.48
Clerical and administrative workers	981	27.81	Education and training	64	8.83
Sales workers	266	7.55	Health care and social assistance	82	11.31
Machinery Operations and drivers	107	3.04	Arts and recreation services	38	5.24
Labours	105	2.99	Other services	38	5.24
Highest education			Location (metropolitan/regional)^e		
Postgraduate degree	353	10.01	Metropolitan (major city)	484	66.76
Graduate diploma and graduate certificate	227	6.44	Regional/rural	239	32.97
Bachelor's degree	738	20.92	Work size		
Advanced diploma and diploma	536	15.20	5–19	241	33.24

Table 1 (*continued*)

Employee level	Number	Percentage	Organisation level	Number	Percentage
Certificate level	835	23.67	20–99	317	43.72
Secondary school	805	22.83	100–199	81	11.17
No completion of any education	33	0.94	200 and above	86	11.86
Total (employees)	3527	100	Total (organisations)	725	100

^aSee Appendix A for more detailed sub-groupings of languages.

^bSee Appendix B for more detailed age categories.

^cThis follows ANZSCO Major Occupations Group. See Appendix C for more detailed occupation categories.

^dIndustry categories follow ANZSIC classification.

^eOrganisations with multiple sites are indicated by the location with the largest share of their employees.

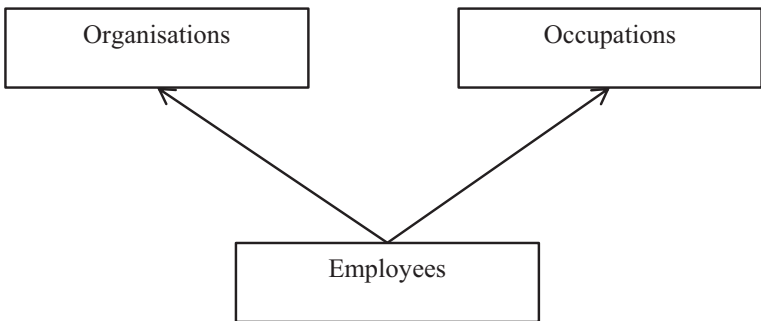


Figure 1 Classification diagram for the two-way cross-classified structure

had gathered information about participants' occupations based on the Australian and New Zealand Standard Classification of Occupations (ANZSCO). An *occupation's gender segregation* was measured by the difference between the proportions of men and women working in a specific occupation (Barón and Cobb-Clark 2010). We subtracted the proportion of women from the proportion of men, so that a positive value indicated more male-dominated occupations while a negative value indicated female-dominated occupations. Larger absolute values indicated higher levels of gender segregation, while smaller values indicated more gender-balanced occupations. This sample-based classification of occupations was consistent with our traditional understanding of female or male occupations. For example, the top three female-dominated occupations in this dataset were numerical clerks, general clerical workers, inquiry clerks and receptionists, while male-dominated occupations included specialist managers, automotive and engineering trade workers and road and rail drivers (see Appendix D for more details).

Dependent variables

For dependent variables, we created three binary variables using the individual survey in the AWRS data: *cross-job mobility preference*, *cross-organisation mobility preference* and *cross-industry mobility preference*. Measuring psychological mobility with a binary variable is a well-received approach in the literature (Cho and Lewis 2012; Ko and Hur 2014; Pitts, Marvel and Fernandez 2011). We created the mobility preference variables using individuals' responses to this question: 'In regard to your job, where do you want to be in 12 months' time?' The participants were asked to choose between five options: 'working for the same employer, in the same role' (option 1), 'working for the same employer, but in a different role' (option 2), 'working for a different employer in the same industry' (option 3), 'working in another industry' (option 4) and 'no longer working' (option 5). We dropped those participants who were no longer working, as we focused on the mobility of incumbent workers, not unemployed workers. Based on the cumulative logit method used to analyse ordinal responses (Leckie, Morris and Steele 2016), we created three binary variables from the original answers: *cross-job mobility preference*, *cross-organisation mobility preference* and *cross-industry mobility preference*, each of which represents one of the three breaks between the four options. *Cross-job mobility preference* differentiated the employees who chose option 1 from those who chose other options. For this variable, 1 indicated a preference to change jobs, and 0 indicated no preference to change at all. *Cross-organisation mobility preference* differentiated the employees who chose options 1 or 2 from those who chose options 3 or 4. In this variable, 1 indicated a preference to change companies, and 0 indicated a preference to stay in the same company. *Cross-industry mobility preference* differentiated the employees who chose option 4 from those who chose other options. In this case, 1 indicated a preference to change industries, and 0 indicated a preference to stay in the same industry.

Control variables

We included control variables at the levels of employee, organisation and industry. First, the employee-level control variables included *employees' marital status*, *tenure*, *multiple jobs*, *duration of unpaid time*, *education*, *job satisfaction* and *wage*. For *marital status*, we included a dummy variable 'single' (1 for 'single'; 0 for 'non-single'). Employees' marital status has been found to influence employees' social roles outside the workplace (Barnett et al. 2003). If employees are married or in a de facto marital relationship, they bear more social roles, which, in turn, affect their mobility preferences (Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019). Previous research documented that employees' tenure affects their mobility tendency (Mitchel 1981). Thus, we included an employee's *tenure*, which was calculated by the number of years and months spent with the current employer. We included *multiple jobs* as a dummy variable, where 1 indicated employees currently holding multiple paid jobs for different employers, and 0 indicated employees holding only one job. Multiple job holding represents a deviation from the traditional within-single-organisation career (Campion, Caza and Moss 2020) and may influence employees' boundaryless career attitudes and mobility preferences (Panos, Pouliakas and Zangelidis 2014). Recent

boundaryless career literature argues that the experience of unpaid employment may also impact employees' attitudes toward a traditional organisational career (Vansteenkiste, Verbruggen and Sels 2013; Waters et al. 2014). The *unpaid duration* was operationalised as an ordinal variable, indicating how long employees were not in paid employment over the past five years: 0 for 'no experience', 1 for 'less than 3 months', 2 for '3 to less than 12 months (one year)', 3 for 'one year to less than two years' and 4 for 'two years or more'. Unpaid time included both unemployment and unpaid leave. Employees' *education* was treated as a continuous variable from 1 to 7, indicating different education levels. Employees' *wage* was operationalised as their hourly wage received for their most recent pay. We also controlled for employees' *job satisfaction*. On a 7-point Likert scale, the employees were asked to what extent they were satisfied with seven aspects of their jobs (7 indicated 'extremely satisfied' and 1 indicated 'extremely dissatisfied'). The example items included 'the flexibility to balance work and non-work commitments', 'the freedom to decide how to do your own work', 'your job security' and so forth. The principal component analysis revealed that all seven items were loaded on one single factor, with factor loadings above 0.7. The Cronbach's alpha (α) was 0.87.

Second, we controlled for several organisational-level variables: *Organisation size* was measured by the total number of employees in each organisation, and *flexible work practices* were measured using the employers' responses to the questions of whether they made flexible work practices available to their employees. We summated these responses to the eight practices specified in the AWRS questionnaire, such as 'flexible start and finish times' and 'regular or formal arrangement for working from home or teleworking from another location'. Finally, we controlled for the *industry* in which each organisation primarily operated. This variable followed the Australian and New Zealand Standard Industrial Classification (ANZSIC).

Analytic approach

We utilised cross-classified multilevel modelling (CCMM) to test the hypotheses. This analytic approach is most appropriate for data with a cross-classified structure in which the lower-level entities (individual employees) are embedded in more than one higher-level entities simultaneously (organisations and occupations). Since the dependent variables were binary, we applied the logistic regression approach in conjunction with CCMM. The model for each boundary-crossing mobility preference (MP) is specified as follows:

$$MP \sim \text{Binomial}(1, \pi_i)$$

$$\begin{aligned} \text{logit}(\pi_i) = & \beta_0 + u_{0,occ(i)}^{(3)} + u_{0,org(i)}^{(2)} + \beta_1 \text{gender}_i + \beta_2 \text{female_leadership}_i \\ & + \beta_3 \text{occ_segregation}_i + \beta_4 \text{occ_segregation}_i^2 + \beta_5 (\text{gender} \\ & * \text{female_leadership})_i + \beta_6 (\text{gender} * \text{occ_segregation})_i + \beta(\text{controls}_i), \end{aligned}$$

where π_i is the probability of employee (i) preferring to cross a certain boundary, $u_{0,occ(i)}^{(3)}$ is the random effect at the occupational level, $u_{0,org(i)}^{(2)}$ is the random effect at the

organisational level and the rest are fixed effects specified by our model. MLwiN via Stata was used to conduct data analysis. The estimation method used was Bayesian estimation, which was implemented via Markov Chain Monte Carlo (MCMC), which is suitable for CCMMs with binary responses (Dunn et al. 2015).

Results

Table 2 presents the descriptive statistics and the correlation matrix. To diagnose any potential problem of multicollinearity, we checked the variance inflation factor (VIF) for each variable. The results revealed that the VIFs of our predictor variables did not exceed 1.39, suggesting that multicollinearity was not a concern for our models (Menard 1995). Women accounted for 57% of the sample. With respect to mobility preferences, most participants (65%) preferred to work in the same role at the same organisation (not mobile). Another 20% preferred to be mobile in the same organisation. Only 6% preferred to work in a different organisation within the same industry, while 9% preferred to work in another industry. This highly unbalanced distribution among the four options is in line with the scarce empirical evidence for boundaryless careers (Inkson et al. 2012). Another reason might be that the original question asked mobility preferences in terms of only the next 12 months – a short timeframe compared with lifetime career processes. Notably, the correlation between gender and cross-industry mobility preference was positive and significant ($r = 0.04, p < 0.05$), showing that women have higher psychological mobility than men when considering moving across industries. However, regarding cross-job mobility and cross-organisation mobility, the correlation coefficients were small and not significant.

Tables 3–5 present the estimation results for the cross-classified multilevel logit models on the factors affecting an employee's mobility preference across jobs (Table 3), organisations (Table 4) and industry (Table 5). Hypothesis 1 predicted that female employees will demonstrate a higher level of cross-boundary mobility preference than their male counterparts. We tested the relationship between gender and mobility preference for each career boundary, and the results suggested that the effect of gender on mobility preference is visible for the cross-industry boundary. As shown in Table 5 (Model 3), women had a higher cross-industry mobility preference than men ($\beta = -0.28, p < 0.1$). This result held and was even strengthened when adding organisation-level interactions ($\beta = -0.69, p < 0.01$ in Model 5; $\beta = -0.67, p < 0.01$ in Model 7). However, gender's impact on mobility preference was not significant on job-based boundary (Table 3, Model 3) and organisation-based boundary (Table 4, Model 3). Hence, hypothesis 1 was supported, but only in the case of cross-industry mobility preference ($p < 0.1$).

Hypothesis 2 proposed that gender-based difference in mobility preference will be more pronounced in more distant boundaries (such as inter-industry boundary rather than inter-organisational boundary). As explained above, gender's impact was significant for cross-industry mobility preference, while it was not significant for inter-organisational and cross-job mobility preferences, which was consistent with hypothesis 2.

Table 2 Descriptive statistics and correlations

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
<i>Individual Level (N = 3527)</i>																
1. Cross-job Mobility Preference (1 = change job; 0 = no change at all)	0.35	0.48														
2. Cross-organisation Mobility Preference (1 = change organisation; 0 = stay in the same organisation)	0.14	0.35	0.56*													
3. Cross-industry Mobility Preference (1 = change industry; 0 = stay in the same industry)	0.09	0.28	0.42*	0.75*												
4. Gender (1 = female; 0 = male)	0.57	0.49	-0.00	-0.00	0.04*											
5. Single (1 = single; 0 = non-single)	0.28	0.45	0.11*	0.09*	0.08*	0.08*										
6. Tenure	5.93	6.01	-0.21*	-0.13*	-0.09*	-0.03	-0.11*									
7. Multiple Job (1 = multiple job)	0.01	0.28	0.06*	0.09*	0.07*	0.03	0.03	-0.07*								
8. Unpaid Duration	0.63	1.03	0.11*	0.09*	0.08*	0.13*	0.04*	-0.31*	0.05*							
9. Highest Education	4.90	1.64	0.06*	0.05*	-0.00	0.00	-0.03	-0.11*	0.09*	0.09*						
10. Job Satisfaction	5.44	1.03	-0.35*	-0.39*	-0.29*	0.05*	-0.05*	0.10*	-0.00	-0.07*	-0.00					
11. Hourly Wage	122.15	451.48	0.02	-0.00	-0.02	-0.09*	-0.04*	-0.00	-0.02	-0.04	0.09*	0.01				
<i>Occupational Level (n = 43)</i>																
12. Gender Segregation	0.00	2.81	-0.03	-0.02	-0.06*	-0.43*	-0.05*	0.02	-0.05*	-0.08*	0.06*	-0.02	0.08*			
<i>Organisational Level (n = 725)</i>																
13. Female-Manager Proportion	0.38	0.34	0.00	0.01	0.01	0.35*	0.03	-0.04*	0.07*	0.07	0.10*	0.02	-0.02	-0.15*		
14. Flexible Work Practices	9.77	4.87	0.03	-0.00	-0.02	0.05*	-0.01	-0.05*	0.00	0.02	0.14*	0.00	0.01	-0.01	0.10*	
15. Organisation Size	111.53	311.68	0.02	-0.02	-0.02	0.03	-0.01	0.06*	-0.02	-0.04	-0.03	-0.05*	-0.02	-0.01	0.01	0.04*

All variables were presented at their appropriate levels. For cross-level correlations, higher-level data were disaggregated to individual level. An asterisk (*) indicates statistical significance at 0.05.

Table 3 Cross-classified logistic results for cross-job mobility preference

DV: cross-job mobility preference (0 = no change at all; 1 = change job)	Model 1 (null model)	Model 2 (controls only)	Model 3 (H1)	Model 4	Model 5 (H3)	Model 6 (H4)	Model 7 (full model)
<i>Fixed effect estimates</i>							
Intercept (SE)	−0.66 (0.08)***	3.45 (0.40)***	3.79 (0.42)***	3.74 (0.50)***	3.62 (0.43)***	4.07 (0.49)***	3.80 (0.39)***
Individual-level							
Single (dummy)		0.35 (0.09)***	0.35 (0.09)***	0.34 (0.09)***	0.33 (0.09)***	0.33 (0.09)***	0.33 (0.10)***
Tenure		−0.08 (0.01)***	−0.09 (0.01)***	−0.08 (0.01)***	−0.08 (0.01)***	−0.09 (0.01)***	−0.08 (0.01)***
Multiple jobs (dummy)		0.33 (0.14)*	0.33 (0.15)*	0.33 (0.15)**	0.31 (0.15)*	0.32 (0.14)*	0.32 (0.15)**
Unpaid duration		0.05 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)	0.05 (0.04)	0.05 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)	0.04 (0.04)
Highest education		0.10 (0.02)***	0.10 (0.03)***	0.09 (0.03)**	0.09 (0.03)**	0.09 (0.03)***	0.09 (0.03)***
Job satisfaction		−0.81 (0.04)***	−0.84 (0.04)***	−0.83 (0.05)***	−0.83 (0.05)***	−0.84 (0.04)***	−0.84 (0.05)***
Wage		0.00 (0.00)*	0.00 (0.00)*	0.00 (0.00)*	0.00 (0.00)*	0.00 (0.00)*	0.00 (0.00)*
Gender (0 = male, 1 = female) (H1)			−0.03 (0.10)	−0.07 (0.10)	0.11 (0.16)	−0.09 (0.10)	0.11 (0.15)
Occupation-level							
Gender segregation				−0.05 (0.02)**	−0.04 (0.02)*	−0.04 (0.02)*	−0.04 (0.03)
Gender segregation square				−0.00 (0.00)+	−0.00 (0.00)	−0.01 (0.00)	−0.01 (0.00)
Organisation-level							
Size		0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.01 (0.00)
Flexible work practices		0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)
Female-manager prop				−0.23 (0.18)	0.12 (0.27)	−0.24 (0.19)+	0.11 (0.26)
Cross-level interactions							
Gender*Female-Manager Prop (H3)					−0.52 (0.31)*		−0.51 (0.28)*
Gender*Gender Segregation (H4)						−0.01 (0.03)	−0.01 (0.03)
<i>Random effect estimates</i>							
U3 Occupation (var)	0.12 (0.04, 0.24)*	0.05 (0.00, 0.14)	0.04 (0.00, 0.14)	0.02 (0.00, 0.10)	0.03 (0.00, 0.13)	0.03 (0.00, 0.13)	0.04 (0.01, 0.18)
U2 Organisation (var)	0.57 (0.39, 0.78)*	0.34 (0.17, 0.52)*	0.37 (0.20, 0.58)*	0.37 (0.17, 0.58)*	0.39 (0.21, 0.61)*	0.39 (0.18, 0.65)*	0.36 (0.18, 0.55)*
Fit statistics							
DIC	4392.31	3861.17	3860.73	3860.37	3858.88	3863.12	3858.74

+*p* 0.1; **p* < 0.05; ***p* < 0.01; ****p* < 0.001. All analyses include industry dummies.

Table 4 Cross-classified logistic results for cross-organisation mobility preference

DV: cross-organisation mobility preference (0 = stay in the same organisation; 1 = change organisation)	Model 1 (null model)	Model 2 (controls only)	Model 3 (H1)	Model 4	Model 5 (H3)	Model 6 (H4)	Model 7 (full model)
<i>Fixed effect estimates</i>							
Intercept (SE)	-1.98 (0.10)***	3.40 (0.61)***	3.48 (0.61)***	3.36 (0.49)***	3.54 (0.54)***	3.43 (0.52)***	3.46 (0.42)***
Individual-level							
Single		0.34 (0.12)**	0.34 (0.12)**	0.33 (0.13)**	0.32 (0.12)**	0.32 (0.13)**	0.31 (0.12)**
Tenure		-0.06 (0.01)***	-0.07 (0.01)***	-0.06 (0.01)***	-0.06 (0.02)***	-0.07 (0.01)***	-0.06 (0.01)***
Multiple jobs		0.68 (0.17)***	0.69 (0.18)**	0.65 (0.17)***	0.66 (0.17)***	0.68 (0.18)***	0.65 (0.18)***
Unpaid duration		0.06 (0.06)	0.06 (0.06)	0.06 (0.06)	0.06 (0.06)	0.06 (0.06)	0.06 (0.05)
Highest education		0.12 (0.04)**	0.12 (0.04)**	0.12 (0.04)**	0.11 (0.04)***	0.12 (0.03)***	0.12 (0.04)***
Job satisfaction		-1.07 (0.06)***	-1.08 (0.07)***	-1.05 (0.06)***	-1.09 (0.05)***	-1.08 (0.05)***	-1.08 (0.06)***
Wage		0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)	0.00 (0.00)
Gender (0 = male, 1 = female) (H1)			-0.01 (0.13)	-0.06 (0.13)	0.22 (0.19)	-0.09 (0.14)	0.18 (0.21)
Occupation-level							
Gender segregation				-0.05 (0.02)*	-0.05 (0.02)*	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.00 (0.03)
Gender segregation square				-0.01 (0.00)*	-0.01 (0.00)*	-0.01 (0.00)*	-0.01 (0.01)*
Organisation-level							
Size		-0.00 (0.00)	-0.00 (0.00)	-0.00 (0.00)	-0.00 (0.00)+	-0.00 (0.00)	-0.00 (0.00)+
Flexible work practices		-0.00 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)
Female-manager prop				-0.15 (0.23)	0.33 (0.36)	-0.14 (0.24)	0.36 (0.35)
Cross-level interactions							
Gender*Female-Manager Prop (H3)					-0.74 (0.41)*		-0.77 (0.41)*
Gender*Gender Segregation (H4)						-0.07 (0.04)*	-0.08 (0.04)*
<i>Random effect estimates</i>							
U3 Occupation (var)	0.15 (0.05, 0.32)*	0.04 (0.00, 0.14)	0.02 (0.00, 0.12)	0.02 (0.00, 0.09)	0.01 (0.00, 0.05)	0.01 (0.00, 0.08)	0.01 (0.00, 0.06)
U2 Organisation (var)	0.65 (0.36, 0.99)*	0.51 (0.19, 0.92)*	0.59 (0.23, 1.00)*	0.53 (0.22, 0.92)*	0.53 (0.22, 0.94)*	0.56 (0.27, 0.96)*	0.54 (0.26, 0.96)*
<i>Fit statistics</i>							
DIC	2819.95	2326.76	2327.91	2326.32	2322.54	2321.92	2321.43

+ $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. All analyses include industry dummies.

Table 5 Cross-classified logistic results for cross-industry mobility preference

DV: cross-industry mobility preference (0 = stay in the same industry; 1 = change industry)	Model 1 (null model)	Model 2 (controls only)	Model 3 (H1)	Model 4	Model 5 (H3)	Model 6 (H4)	Model 7 (full model)
<i>Fixed effect estimates</i>							
Intercept (SE)	−2.70 (0.16)***	0.86 (0.89)	0.74 (0.59)	1.26 (0.81)*	0.91 (0.64) ⁺	0.95 (0.05)*	0.91 (0.57)*
Individual-level							
Single (dummy)		0.38 (0.15)**	0.35 (0.15)*	0.36 (0.15)**	0.32 (0.16)*	0.35 (0.15)**	0.32 (0.15)*
Tenure		−0.05 (0.02)***	−0.05 (0.02)**	−0.05 (0.02)***	−0.05 (0.02)**	−0.05 (0.02)**	−0.05 (0.02)***
Multiple jobs (dummy)		0.74 (0.22)***	0.72 (0.20)**	0.73 (0.21)***	0.70 (0.22)***	0.73 (0.21)***	0.71 (0.21)**
Unpaid duration		0.10 (0.07) ⁺	0.09 (0.07) ⁺	0.09 (0.08) ⁺	0.09 (0.07) ⁺	0.09 (0.07) ⁺	0.09 (0.07) ⁺
Highest education		0.09 (0.05)*	0.09 (0.05)*	0.08 (0.05) ⁺	0.06 (0.04) ⁺	0.07 (0.05) ⁺	0.08 (0.05) ⁺
Job satisfaction		−0.89 (0.07)***	−0.86 (0.05)***	−0.89 (0.06)***	−0.89 (0.07)***	−0.89 (0.06)***	−0.89 (0.06)***
Wage		−0.00 (0.00)	−0.00 (0.00)	−0.00 (0.00)	−0.00 (0.00)	−0.00 (0.00)	−0.00 (0.00)
Gender (0 = male, 1 = female) (H1)			0.29 (0.16)⁺	0.17 (0.16)	0.69 (0.22)**	0.15 (0.17)	0.67 (0.26)**
Occupation-level							
Gender segregation				−0.08 (0.05)*	−0.08 (0.05) ⁺	−0.07 (0.05) ⁺	−0.05 (0.05)
Gender segregation square				−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.01)
Organisation-level							
Size		−0.00 (0.00)*	−0.00 (0.00)*	−0.00 (0.00)*	−0.00 (0.00)*	−0.00 (0.00)*	−0.00 (0.00)*
Flexible work practices		−0.02 (0.02)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.02 (0.02) ⁺	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.02 (0.02) ⁺
Female-manager prop				−0.25 (0.28)	0.76 (0.42)*	−0.24 (0.30)	0.75 (0.47) ⁺
Cross-level interactions							
Gender*Female-Manager Prop (H3)					−1.43 (0.48)***		−1.44 (0.50)**
Gender*Gender Segregation (H4)						−0.04 (0.05)	−0.05 (0.05)
<i>Random effect estimates</i>							
U3 Occupation (var)	0.43 (0.19, 0.83)*	0.28 (0.12, 0.86) ⁺	0.30 (0.09, 0.67)*	0.30 (0.08, 0.73) ⁺	0.25 (0.04, 0.67) ⁺	0.27 (0.07, 0.64) ⁺	0.27 (0.05, 0.68)
U2 Organisation (var)	0.67 (0.26, 1.15)*	0.77 (0.38, 1.34)*	0.68 (0.38, 1.04)*	0.74 (0.33, 1.50)*	0.76 (0.33, 1.25)*	0.79 (0.25, 1.28)*	0.89 (0.39, 1.50)*
<i>Fit statistics</i>							
DIC	1975.32	1725.13	1725.06	1727.47	1723.83	1727.11	1720.89

⁺ $p < 0.1$; * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$. All analyses include industry dummies.

Hypothesis 3 predicted a negative moderating effect of organisational female leadership on the relationship between females and their mobility preference. As shown in Model 5 of Tables 3–5, across all the dependent variables, the interactions between gender and female manager proportion were all negatively significant ($\beta = -0.52, p < 0.05$ for cross-job mobility; $\beta = -0.74, p < 0.05$ for cross-organisational mobility; and $\beta = -1.43, p < 0.001$ for cross-industry mobility). To better understand the nature of interaction effects, we drew interaction plots for the cross-job, cross-organisation and cross-industry mobility preferences (displayed in Figures 2–4, respectively). The similarities between these three figures indicate that the moderating effect of an organisation’s female leadership is rather stable across the different types of career boundaries. For all the mobility preferences in this study, we found that when organisations had a large proportion of female managers (one standard deviation above the mean), female employees were less likely to prefer mobility than were their male colleagues. Conversely, in organisations with a small proportion of female managers (one standard deviation below the mean), female employees were more likely to prefer mobility. Hypothesis 3 was thus supported.

Hypothesis 4 posited that occupational gender segregation (male dominance) negatively moderates the relationship between gender and mobility preference. As can be seen in Model 6, the results were inconsistent and more complex. While the coefficients of the interaction between gender and occupational gender segregation were all negative, they were significant only when the dependent variable was cross-organisation mobility preference ($\beta = -0.07, p < 0.05$ in Model 6, Table 4). The results show that, in typically female occupations (one standard deviation below the mean), female employees were more likely to prefer mobility across organisations than were their male counterparts, whereas in typically male occupations (one standard deviation above the mean), female employees were

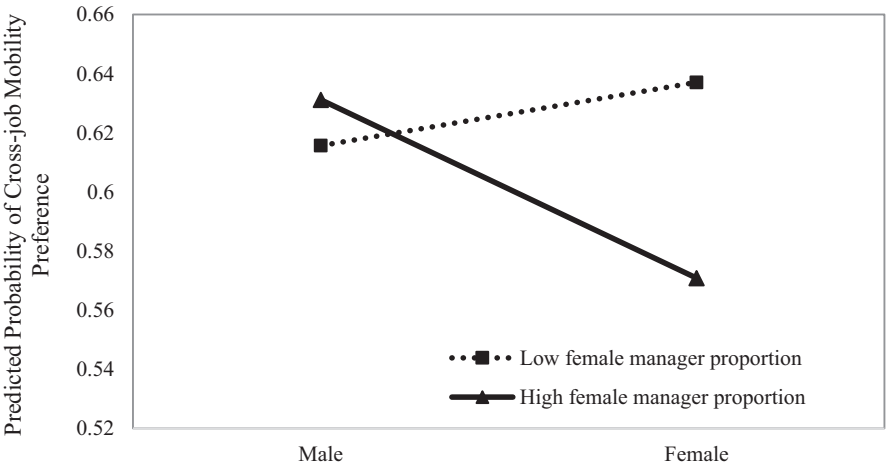


Figure 2 Interaction plot of female manager proportion and gender (cross-job mobility preference)

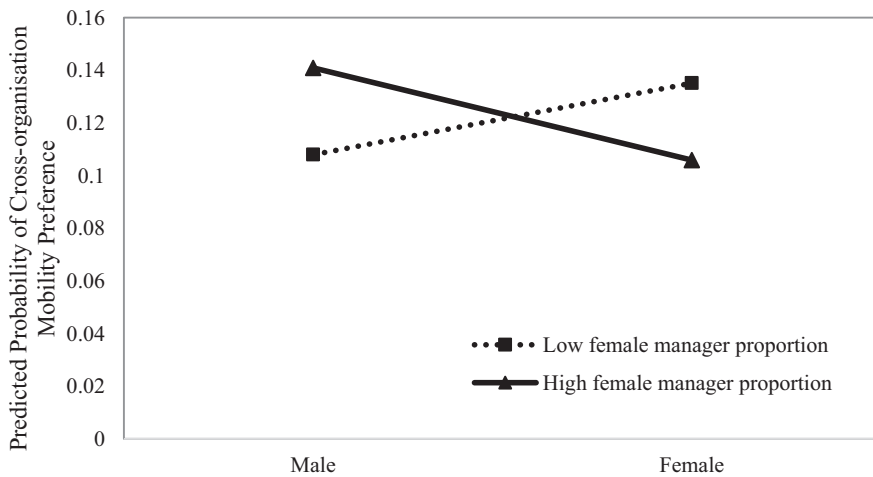


Figure 3 Interaction between female manager proportion and gender (cross-organisation mobility preference)

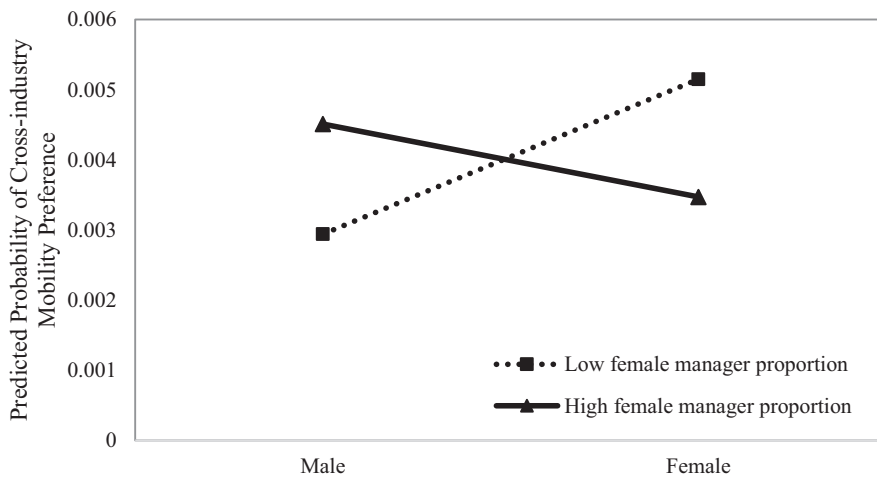


Figure 4 Interaction between female manager proportion and gender (cross-industry mobility preference)

less likely to prefer mobility across organisations (see Figure 5). In more gender-balanced occupations, on the other hand, no gender difference was detected in inter-organisational mobility preferences. In conclusion, hypothesis 4 was partially supported only when inter-organisational mobility was under consideration.

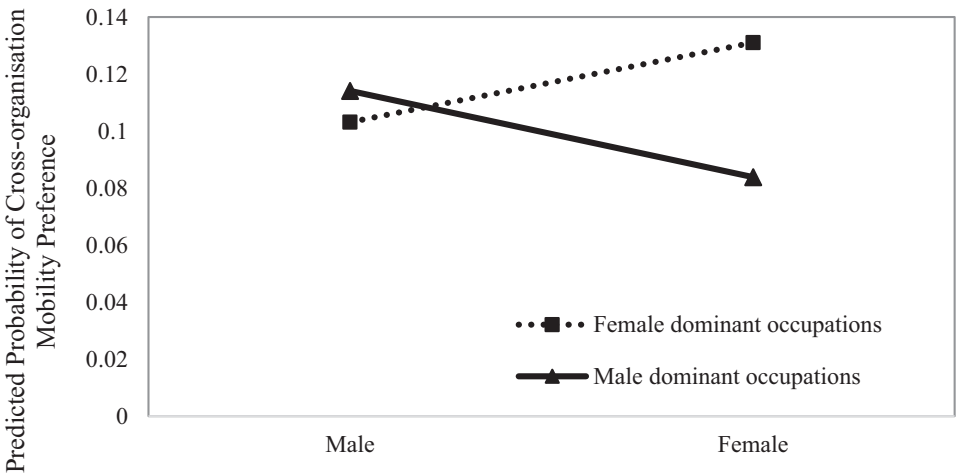


Figure 5 Interaction between occupational segregation and gender (cross-organisation mobility preference)

Discussion

Drawing on the social role theory of gender and using a sample of 3,527 employees from Australia, this study empirically examined the relationship between gender dynamics and employees’ mobility preferences across three different boundaries. No significant relationship was found between gender and mobility preferences, with only one exception. When the mobility preferences across industries were considered, female employees were found to have a slightly higher mobility preference than male employees. The role of gender dynamics on mobility preferences with two higher-level gender (in)equality indicators – organisational-level female leadership and occupational-level gender segregation – were also tested. The results of the cross-classified logistic analysis revealed that in organisations with a higher female manager proportion, female employees had significantly lower mobility preferences across all boundaries. Moreover, occupational gender segregation was found to moderate the relationship between gender and mobility preference only in the case of crossing organisations. In male-dominated occupations, female employees were found to have lower mobility preferences across organisations than male employees, and in female-dominated occupations, female employees were found to have higher mobility preferences than male employees. One possible explanation for this result is that occupational choice itself works as an effective filter that separates women with different career attitudes and aspirations. Women in male-dominated occupations have been found to be more confident, dominant, adventurous and traditionally success-driven than women in typical female-dominated occupations (Lemkau 1979; Ramaci et al. 2017). Hence, they are more eager to achieve traditional career success by following a linear

progression within an organisation. This also explains why similar moderating effects were not found in mobility preferences across the other two boundaries.

We conducted an additional analysis to support the above explanation. In the survey, employees were asked whether they considered ‘the freedom to decide how to do your own work’ (hereafter ‘freedom’) important when considering job satisfaction. This information can be a decent, but not perfect, indicator of employees’ confidence and dominance in doing their work. Simple correlation results indicated that the importance employees give to freedom was positively correlated with occupational male dominance ($r = 0.05$, $p < 0.001$) and negatively correlated with cross-organisation mobility preference ($r = -0.07$, $p < 0.001$). More importantly, female employees in male-dominated occupations were more likely to consider freedom important when compared with female employees in female-dominated occupations ($F(1, 2712) = 4.7$, $p = 0.03$). However, no significant difference was found among male employees from different occupations ($F(1, 1948) = 0.04$, $p = 0.83$).

Theoretical implications

Mobility preference leads to employees’ actual turnover (Cho and Lewis 2012) and thus poses a challenge to organisations seeking to maintain their human capital resources (Coff 1997; Nyberg et al. 2018). As the labour market becomes dynamic and fluid, employees’ mobility preferences and job choices are driven by an increasingly diverse range of factors (Griffeth, Hom and Gaertner 2000; Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021). Gender dynamics in career choices have been the subject of scholarly research for some time (Kossek et al. 2017; Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019; Rocha and Van Praag 2020). However, previous studies have found ambiguous results regarding whether male or female employees show different mobility preferences (Kattenbach et al. 2014; Mölders et al. 2019). We contribute to the understanding of gender’s role in career choices by drawing from the social role theory of gender (Anglin et al. 2022; Eagly 1987). According to this theory, any actions or decisions taken by employees are made in consideration of their social roles and social relations. This suggests that men and women understand their career success differently, due to their distinct social expectations and their different social relations (Mainiero and Sullivan 2005). Gender expectations and gender roles are socially constructed (Jiang et al. 2012) and are widely internalised by individuals (Rocha and Van Praag 2020). As a consequence, men and women tend to have different career preferences and choices (Carnahan, Kryscynski and Olson 2017; Kossek et al. 2017; Sauermann 2018). As Schein mentioned (1984, 72), institutions influence ‘the importance of career relative to personal and family issues’. In many societies, women are expected to construct their career aspirations and success in consideration of their families (Crompton 2002; Pas et al. 2014; Rocha and Van Praag 2020; Woehler et al. 2021). Future research could further illuminate contextual factors that affect gender dynamics of career choices and mobility preferences.

This study may inspire future research on the relationship between gender and career by highlighting the multiplicity of career boundaries (job, organisation and industry).

Over the recent decades, the concept of the ‘boundaryless career’ has received much attention (Inkson et al. 2012; Kornblum et al. 2018; Loacker and Śliwa 2016). Building on this idea, many studies focused on examining how permeable a particular career boundary (such as inter-organisational boundary) could be (Gubler et al. 2014). For instance, Gorji et al. (2020) examined gender-based career dynamics focusing on within-industry career mobility. We extend this boundaryless career discussion by explicitly recognising the complexity of career boundaries, rather than focusing on the boundaryless nature of career movement. This study also echoes the growing interest in differentiating mobility types (e.g. Kornblum et al. 2018; Sullivan and Al Ariss 2021), which influence employees’ attitudes and preferences (Zimmerman, Swider and Arthur 2020).

This study affirms the importance of institutional and social settings in modifying employees’ career attitudes and behaviours (Guan et al. 2019; Holtschlag et al. 2020; Kinsella et al. 2022; Kost et al. 2020; Tomlinson et al. 2018; Zeitz et al. 2009). Specifically, we demonstrated that the relationship between gender and mobility preferences is affected by gender compositions within organisations and occupations. We observed that gender inequality at the firm level – female representation in leadership – and gender imbalance at the occupation level may lead to differences in mobility preference. This finding verifies that individuals’ career preferences are not only a matter of individual agency but also a matter of structural social issues (Kornblum et al. 2018; Rodrigues et al. 2019). The societal pressures and expectations may result in gender differences in individuals identifying their roles in a family and in their workplace. Explicitly incorporating contextual factors can thus help us better understand gender’s effects in the workplace in general and on mobility preferences in particular. Future gender workplace research could consider other organisational and occupational variables to better understand individual differences (e.g. Ely and Padavic 2007; Ramaswami et al. 2010).

Practical implications

Our findings have several implications for practitioners. First, managers should be cognisant of gender differences in career preferences. The results of our study show that the mobility destination matters differently depending on employees’ gender (Zimmerman et al. 2020). Specifically, female workers have a higher mobility preference to change industries, while male workers have a higher mobility preference across organisations but within the same industry. In other words, while the constraining effects of organisational boundaries might be decreasing for both men and women, the effects of industry boundaries are different. On the one hand, managers should pay close attention to male workers’ turnover since they have higher chances of joining competing firms. Turnover scholars have argued that employee turnover to competing firms or starting a new venture in the same industry is more detrimental to firm function (e.g. Lee et al. 2017). On the other hand, the different destinations also indicate different reasons why male and female workers leave their jobs. The constraining effects of industry boundaries stem from a higher loss of human capital (Robinson 2018). Our results show that men care more about maintaining their human capital compared with women when considering mobility.

Managers should be aware that different interventions are needed to retain male and female workers. For female employees, organisations might consider providing supervisor support for family roles and responsibilities (Kossek, Perrigino and Rock 2021; Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019; Rasheed et al. 2018). For male employees, organisations should provide more professional support that enhances their human capital and marketability.

Second, our findings highlight the importance of having a good gender balance in leadership positions. According to our results, female leadership could help retain female workers. Because men still dominate organisational hierarchies (Evans and Maley 2021), more female leadership signals an organisation's efforts to promote gender equality. The argued low career motivation of female workers has largely resulted from gender inequality or the 'glass ceiling' in the workplace (Lewellyn and Muller-Kahle 2020; Memon and Jena 2017; Pas et al. 2014). As members of a minority in the workplace, females observing other females' career achievements serve as career encouragement for them to achieve their traditional career goals. Our results offer evidence that organisations aiming to address gender inequality are not only legitimate but also efficient in terms of maintaining workforce diversity (Woehler et al. 2021). Managers can create a supportive environment for female workers by providing more career encouragement (Nguyen and Shao 2019). This will increase female employees' career motivations and, hence, reduce subsequent mobility preferences (Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019).

Third, policy-makers should be aware of the impact of occupational gender composition. Due to the internalised schemas associated with gender-appropriate occupations, there is gender inequality in many occupations (Adamovic and Leibbrandt 2023; Javdani and McGee 2019). Therefore, different career attitudes or behaviours may emerge in occupations with different gender compositions. Specifically, our findings suggest that women in male-dominated occupations behave differently from women in female-dominated occupations. When they are situated in a male-dominated occupational context, they prefer less to move across organisations than their male counterparts. A possible explanation for this is that women in male-dominated occupations tend to have a non-traditional gender role attitude that supports their career motivations. Otherwise, they tend to accept the gendered division of labour and choose female-dominated occupations (Paustian-Underdahl et al. 2019). As occupational gender segregation inevitably leads to gender discrimination (e.g. Adamovic and Leibbrandt 2023) and deters counter-gender job-seekers (He et al. 2019), it is detrimental to the development of both the focal occupation and the society. Therefore, policy-makers should further adjust education programs to promote female inclusion in male-dominated careers (Kossek et al. 2017).

Limitations and future research

This study has several limitations that could be addressed in future research. First, it carries the advantages as well as the limitations of using data that were not collected specifically for the stated purposes of the study, thus posing some challenges to developing testable models (Hox and Boeije 2005). For instance, the mobility preferences in the study were treated as binary variables, while the relative literature has largely used scales (e.g. De

Vos, Dewettinck and Buyens 2008; Ng and Feldman 2015). Moreover, this dataset asked about employees' mobility preferences only over 12 months, which is a short time compared with lifetime career processes. Career attitudes may not lead to a higher mobility preference over such a short timeframe. Further studies could collect more detailed data on employees' mobility preferences across different time spans.

Second, though this study utilised a large sample (3,529 employees and 725 employers), the number of occupations was low. However, we believe that this is not an issue; for CCMM, 43 is an acceptable and credible number that enabled us to reliably estimate the between-occupation variance. This is also the specific number of occupation categories according to ANZSCO, and increasing the number of occupations would be arbitrary. Moreover, to the best of our knowledge, the AWRS dataset is the best one available for testing our research question.

Third, our study examined gender differences in only mobility preferences. Further studies could consider examining whether those mobility preferences will eventually lead to actual mobility. However, the remaining employees with high turnover intentions may hamper firms' productivity, and replacing them with new hires may be better. Therefore, understanding employees' mobility preferences or turnover intentions, in addition to their close association with actual mobility, is critical and could offer insightful implications for managers.

Conclusion

This study investigated gender differences in mobility preferences. The results of the CCMM using the AWRS data suggest that gender differences in mobility preferences across different boundaries depend on organisational and occupational environments. First, the mobility preferences of men and women do not differ significantly in gender-balanced occupations (i.e. arts and media professionals, sales support workers and so on) or in organisations with a moderate proportion of female managers. Except for inter-industry mobility, women tend to have higher mobility preferences than men. Second, the results supported our hypothesis about the moderating effect of an organisation's proportion of female managers in all cross-boundary cases. Finally, the effect of an occupation's gender composition seems rather weak compared with that of an organisation. Surprisingly, an occupation's gender segregation moderates the relationship between gender and mobility preference across only organisational boundaries. We encourage future researchers to further investigate gender dynamics in cross-boundary career mobility in the post-COVID, technology-driven environment where new patterns of career boundaries are emerging.

Conflict of interest

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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Appendix A

Description of sample employees by spoken language

Languages	Number of sample employees	Percentage
English only	3022	85.68
Italian	40	1.13
Greek	26	0.74
Cantonese	31	0.88
Arabic	7	0.20
Mandarin	45	1.28
Vietnamese	17	0.48
Afrikaans	9	0.26
Filipino/Tagalog	29	0.82
French	24	0.68
German	15	0.43
Hindi	24	0.68
Indonesian	11	0.31
Japanese	11	0.31
Korean	7	0.20
Polish	7	0.20
Portuguese	7	0.20
Russian	9	0.26
Serbian/Croatian	14	0.40
Sinhala	10	0.28
Spanish	14	0.40
Indian/Bengali	16	0.45
Other	109	3.09
Missing	23	0.66
Total	3527	100

Appendix B

Description of sample employees by age

Age	Number of sample employees	Percentage
15–17 years	14	0.40
18–20 years	72	2.04
21–24 years	260	7.37
25–29 years	466	13.21
30–34 years	449	12.73
35–39 years	421	11.94
40–44 years	430	12.19
45–49 years	413	11.71
50–54 years	395	11.20
55–59 years	308	8.73
60–64 years	164	4.65
65–69 years	40	1.13
70–74 years	5	0.14
More than 75 years	4	0.11
Missing	86	2.44
Total	3527	100

Appendix C

Description of sample employees by occupations

Occupation (ANZSCO)	Number of sample employees	Percentage	Occupation (ANZSCO)	Number of sample employees	Percentage
11. Chief Executives, General Managers and Legislators	107	3.03	51. Office Managers and Program Administrators	240	6.80
12. Farmers and Farm Managers	2	0.06	52. Personal Assistants and Secretaries	110	3.12
13. Specialist Managers	391	11.09	53. General Clerical Workers	160	4.54

Appendix C (*continued*)

Occupation (ANZSCO)	Number of sample employees	Percentage	Occupation (ANZSCO)	Number of sample employees	Percentage
14. Hospitality, Retail and Service Managers	203	5.76	54. Inquiry Clerks and Receptionists	127	3.60
21. Arts and Media Professionals	16	0.45	55. Numerical Clerks	237	6.72
22. Business, Human Resource and Marketing Professionals	386	10.94	56. Clerical and Office Support Workers	11	0.31
23. Design, Engineering, Science and Transport Professionals	74	2.10	59. Other Clerical and Administrative Workers	96	2.72
24. Education Professionals	141	4.00	61. Sales Representatives and Agents	111	3.15
25. Health Professionals	92	2.61	62. Sales Assistants and Salespersons	140	3.97
26. ICT Professionals	65	1.84	63. Sales Support Workers	15	0.43
27. Legal, Social and Welfare Professionals	43	1.22	71. Machine and Stationary Plant Operators	24	0.68
31. Engineering, ICT and Science Technicians	89	2.52	72. Mobile Plant Operators	12	0.34
32. Automotive and Engineering Trades Workers	70	1.98	73. Road and Rail Drivers	38	1.08
33. Construction Trades Workers	44	1.25	74. Store Persons	33	0.94
34. Electrotechnology and Telecommunications Trades Workers	27	0.77	81. Cleaners and Laundry Workers	27	0.77

Appendix C (*continued*)

Occupation (ANZSCO)	Number of sample employees	Percentage	Occupation (ANZSCO)	Number of sample employees	Percentage
35. Food Trades Workers	28	0.79	82. Construction and Mining Labourers	9	0.26
36. Skilled Animal and Horticultural Workers	6	0.17	83. Factory Process Workers	29	0.82
39. Other Technicians and Trades Workers	31	0.88	84. Farm, Forestry and Garden Workers	6	0.17
41. Health and Welfare Support Workers	35	0.99	85. Food Preparation Assistants	9	0.26
42. Carers and Aides	60	1.70	89. Other Labourers	25	0.71
43. Hospitality Workers	101	2.86	Female dominated	1935	54.86
44. Protective Service Workers	18	0.51	Male dominated	1592	45.12
45. Sports and Personal Service Workers	39	1.11	Total	3527	100.00

Appendix D**Occupational gender segregation**

ANZSCO code	Occupation name	Share of female workforce (F) ^a	Share of male workforce (M) ^b	Gender segregation (M-F)
13	Specialist Managers	7.66	12.86	5.20
32	Automotive and Engineering Trades Workers	0.04	4.52	4.48
73	Road and Rail Drivers	0.04	3.53	3.50
31	Engineering, ICT and Science Technicians	0.99	4.37	3.38
11	Chief Executives, General Managers and Legislators	1.42	4.66	3.24

Appendix D (*continued*)

ANZSCO code	Occupation name	Share of female workforce (F) ^a	Share of male workforce (M) ^b	Gender segregation (M-F)
26	ICT Professionals	0.71	3.29	2.58
33	Construction Trades Workers	0.04	2.50	2.47
14	Hospitality, Retail and Service Managers	4.19	6.63	2.44
23	Design, Engineering, Science and Transport Professionals	1.31	3.68	2.37
34	Electrotechnology and Telecommunications Trades Workers	0.00	2.16	2.16
74	Store Persons	0.14	2.16	2.02
71	Machine and Stationary Plant Operators	0.39	1.82	1.43
39	Other Technicians and Trades Workers	0.32	1.67	1.35
89	Other Labourers	0.21	1.42	1.21
35	Food Trades Workers	0.35	1.47	1.12
83	Factory Process Workers	0.50	1.57	1.07
59	Other Clerical and Administrative Workers	2.23	3.24	1.01
72	Mobile Plant Operators	0.04	0.93	0.90
82	Construction and Mining Labourers	0.04	0.83	0.80
44	Protective Service Workers	0.25	0.98	0.73
61	Sales Representatives and Agents	2.87	3.53	0.66
84	Farm, Forestry and Garden Workers	0.18	0.44	0.26
12	Farmers and Farm Managers	0.00	0.20	0.20
45	Sports and Personal Service Workers	1.06	1.23	0.16
36	Skilled Animal and Horticultural Workers	0.25	0.39	0.14
63	Sales Support Workers	0.46	0.49	0.03
21	Arts and Media Professionals	0.50	0.49	−0.01
85	Food Preparation Assistants	0.50	0.25	−0.25
56	Clerical and Office Support Workers	0.53	0.25	−0.29
41	Health and Welfare Support Workers	1.14	0.44	−0.69

Appendix D (*continued*)

ANZSCO code	Occupation name	Share of female workforce (F) ^a	Share of male workforce (M) ^b	Gender segregation (M-F)
27	Legal, Social and Welfare Professionals	1.45	0.49	−0.96
81	Cleaners and Laundry Workers	1.45	0.44	−1.01
43	Hospitality Workers	3.87	2.16	−1.71
24	Education Professionals	4.82	2.80	−2.03
62	Sales Assistants and Salespersons	5.32	3.09	−2.23
22	Business, Human Resource and Marketing Professionals	11.39	8.89	−2.50
42	Carers and Aides	3.23	0.69	−2.54
25	Health Professionals	3.87	0.98	−2.88
51	Office Managers and Program Administrators	7.88	4.47	−3.41
52	Personal Assistants and Secretaries	4.36	0.54	−3.82
54	Inquiry Clerks and Receptionists	7.06	1.03	−6.03
53	General Clerical Workers	7.24	0.64	−6.60
55	Numerical Clerks	9.72	1.77	−7.95

^a F means the number of female employees working in the focal occupation divided by the total female employees in the workplaces.

^b M means the number of male employees working in the focal occupation divided by the total number of male employees in the workplace.